

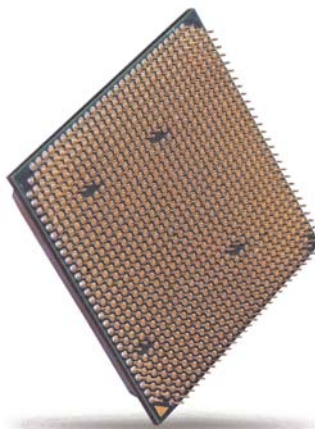


## AM2 5000+ And ASUS M5N SLI 32

AMD 64 + DDR2 = AM2

AMD has moved to the newer DDR2 memory with its 90 nm, Fab 30 plant in Dresden, Germany. The new AM2s are 940-pin processors, up one pin from the older 939 series.

We got an AM2 5000+ CPU, an ASUS M2N 32 SLI, and a dual-channel 2 GB kit of Corsair DDR2 800 MHz RAM. The AM2 5000+ is a top-of-the-line CPU clocked at 2.6 GHz. It features a humongous 256 KB of L1 cache (128 KB for each core), and 1 MB of L2 cache (512 KB for each core).



There is a 2 MB L2 cache version available as well, the 5200+, which is clocked identically.

ASUS, whose enthusiast boards are well-known, have delivered another beauty in the M2N32-SLI Deluxe. It's based on NVIDIA's latest nForce 590 SLI MCP, and features top-end enthusiast features such as two x16 PCI express slots, a unique 8-phase power design, e-SATA (external SATA), and complete silence via a single-piece copper heat pipe setup, which looks cool while keeping components that way!

Feature-wise, this motherboard has nearly everything needed to keep you future-proof for at least a couple of years.

Our memory subsystem consisted of 2 GB of Corsair's high performance XMS 2 series DDR2 800 MHz memory. The memory is timed at 4-4-4-12, which is sufficiently low for the gamer audience. To test such a setup you should have the best graphics card out there as well, so we used two XFX 7900 GTX graphics cards in SLI mode.



Once set up, the rig looked mean, with the CPU heat sink's copper pipes blending in well with all the copper ASUS crammed onto the board. The two huge XFX 7900 GTX cards added to the monster look.

Super Pi gave us a 1M score of 33.110, which is on par with the earlier 939 processors of a similar clock speed. Considering that the AM2 platform is new and that future refinements can only improve performance, this score is great.

PC Mark 05 gave a CPU score of 5348—very decent—and a memory score of 4886, which seemed a tad low. Science Mark 2.0 gave a

very decent memory bandwidth score of 7294 MBps. This Science Mark score is encouraging, because there was scepticism about whether the additional bandwidth that the DDR2 memory provided would be utilised or not.

Future revisions will only see this figure go up. Even in its current avatar, it's much more than the theoretical cap of 6400 MBps that DDR limits memory bandwidth to, although on the negative side, it's still short of the 12.8 GBps that DDR2 800 in dual-channel mode is capable of.

For some real-world testing, we decided to fire up a few games on this monster. Running F.E.A.R. (the latest card killer from Monolith), we got an average fps score of 119—this at 1024 x 768 with 4x Anti-Aliasing and 8x Anisotropic Filtering enabled. Soft Shadows were kept on. The game looked surreal, and the visuals excellent!

We tried various resolutions and just couldn't get this rig to slow down. Even at 2048 x 1536, with 16x AF and 4x AA as well as all the eye candy enabled, the 7900GTX duo hardly seemed to sweat, with an average fps of 51. 3D Mark 06 & 05 returned blazing scores of 8847 and 12246 respectively.

Although these are strictly graphics

## Bazaar is back!

We've re-introduced the Bazaar section—by popular demand from you, our dear readers!

For those of you who have been with us for some time, the section remains the same: this space is devoted to reviews of the latest hardware and software to have hit the market—some great, some average.

We trust the reviews here will help you make better, more informed purchase decisions—besides bringing new products to your notice.

benchmarks, the CPU and memory subsystems do play a significant role here, and the AM2 5000+ quite simply blew us away!

This was a sneak peak for us as well as to what the next generation of CPUs and platforms in general are capable of, and we weren't disappointed. AM2s cost a bomb right now; ditto the nForce 5 series of motherboards. However, with Intel's Conroe round the corner, it makes sense to hold on to your wallet just that bit longer!

### Specifications

#### AMD AM2 5000+

Dual-core, 2.6 GHz, 512 KB x 2 L2 cache, 90 nm fab process, 2000 MHz system bus speed

#### ASUS M5N SLI 32

nForce 590SLI chipset, Socket AM2 (940 pin), 2 x 16 PCIe lane graphics slots (SLI-ready), passive heat-pipe cooling

Contact: AMD India Ltd  
Phone: 080-41372400  
E-mail: deepanshu.sharma@amd.com  
Web site: www.amd.com  
Price: Rs 32,000 (processor);  
Rs 46,000 (processor + motherboard)

### RATINGS

|                 |       |
|-----------------|-------|
| Performance     | ★★★★★ |
| Features        | ★★★★★ |
| Build quality   | ★★★★★ |
| Value for money | ★★★★★ |
| Overall         | ★★★★★ |